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Culture (OWC): [Mossi \(FA28\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1954-1956

Coverage Date: 1954-1956

Place Coverage: Burkina Faso

Section Title(S): Mossi Joking

Mossi Joking¹

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Material Not Relevant

Some important aspects of the joking relationship as an adjustive mechanism have not yet been explicitly recognized, although they have been implicit in the literature on joking for nearly half a century—since before Eggan (1937: 75–81) made his valuable formulation and prior to the appearance of the two classic papers by Radcliffe-Brown (1940, 1949) and the important analysis by Murdock (1949: 272–283). In fact, evidence for them is present in the materials used by these three scholars themselves. But certain aspects of its full significance have remained unexplored.

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For Africa, evidence of these important but so far neglected aspects of [joking is contained in the early descriptive work of Fortes \(1949\), Griaule \(1948\), Labouret \(1929\), and Paulme \(1939\)](#) on West Africa, and it is abundant in more contemporary accounts from that area, e.g., Goody (1956) and Tait (1961). For Central Africa, from which extensive materials are likewise available for comparison, the [early reports of Moreau \(1941\), Pedler \(1940\), and Richards \(1927\)](#) appear to be corroborated by the more recent studies of [Colson \(1953\), Cunnison \(1959\), Watson \(1958\), Turner \(1957\), and Christensen \(1963\)](#).

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Some of the interesting implications of the data contained in these papers have not been developed. There has been a persistent tendency either to limit theoretical considerations of joking to a reaffirmation of the brilliant, but

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loose, analysis made by Radcliffe-Brown or to ignore the theoretical significance of joking altogether. Where there has been criticism it has been largely negative, or the narrower problem of the role of sex as the precipitating factor in conflict regulated by joking has been offered as an alternative emphasis (Brant 1948; Murdock 1949).

Despite the limitations of Radcliffe-Brown's analysis—the important aspects of joking it ignores—no equally ample or comprehensive alternative has been proposed. This paper is presented, not as a refutation of his position, but as a tentative step toward its amplification and emendation.

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Radcliffe-Brown (1940: 195) described joking as a "relationship between two persons in which one is by custom permitted, and in some instances required, to tease or make fun of the other," who in turn is required not to take offense. He recognized that joking often occurs both within and between kin groups and between tribes, and he identified the distinction between symmetrical and asymmetrical types of joking. All such joking was explained by him (Radcliffe-Brown 1940: 200) as a means of reconciling what he termed the "conjunctive" and "disjunctive" aspects of single relationships. The development of serious hostility was said to be prevented ²⁶⁰ by the "playful antagonism of teasing," and he argued that the regular repetition of joking serves as a reminder of the social "disjunction" of the relation, while "conjunction" is simultaneously maintained by friendliness.

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1. A shorter version of this paper was read at the annual meeting of the American Anthropological Association held in San Francisco in November, 1963. It is based on field research conducted among the Mossi from 1954 to 1956 with the assistance of a Ford Foundation Fellowship.

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